



1 BILLION
EXPECTED NUMBER OF
DIGITAL SCREENS BY FY25



1.5 BILLION
NO. OF HOURS INDIANS SPENT WATCHING SPORTS
ONLINE IN 2021, THE HIGHEST IN THE WORLD

SOURCE FICCI-EY REPORT 2022

can command a better ARPU than Hotstar. So, Viacom18 sees IPL more as a customer acquisition strategy for them to cross-sell other content to IPL customers.”

At the end of FY22, 85 per cent of OTT viewership in India was generated by telcos through bundled offers, according to a Ficci-EY report. “If you have prime content like IPL exclusively on Jio for two months, people will move from other telcos to access it,” adds Chhapparwal.

IPL’s digital viewership is projected to touch 523 million in FY23 and 722 million by FY28 from 450 million in FY22, according to Ficci-EY.

THE FUTURE

Viacom18’s approach to IPL and other sports rights it accumulates is going to be different from that of Disney Star, according to experts. “Voot doesn’t have the technical expertise of Hotstar to telecast live sport. Hence, it has to be a completely new brand path, identity, offering and platform that can become a gateway for even non-sports lovers to consume sports content,” says a source with direct knowledge of the developments.

Interactivity, including new-age tech like Web 3.0 and the metaverse, is going to define sports streaming in future. Industry experts feel “watch, shop, interact and customise” will be the cornerstone of OTTs.

According to industry sources, Viacom18 is actively looking to invest in technologies across video, camera, data and analytics to build new and nuanced customisations and experiences for the IPL. “We plan to invest in significant surround content for IPL that can marry sports and pop culture. We are on the lookout for plug-and-play solutions for interactive streaming. And that is the battle we are fighting with the BCCI (Board of Control for Cricket in India) right now... to allow us to do those things,” says a person with direct knowledge of the matter.

Quidich Innovation Labs, a Mumbai-based sports tech startup that works with various stakeholders in sports broadcasting, including the BCCI, IPL, and other platforms, is said to have held talks with Viacom18 on building these customisations and interactive experiences in the upcoming seasons of the league. “We’ve had deep conversations with all sides soon after the auction. There’s a lot of deep tech innovation using AI, ML and player-tracking engines in real time that we are do-

ing with sports, which is hard for the stakeholders to do themselves. But what these [costly] rights have done is push the broadcasters towards innovation,” says its Founder & CEO Rahat Kulshreshtha.

Globally, sports streaming is increasingly being customised according to each person’s interest and viewing pattern. “There is a fundamental shift in thinking and building for OTT,” says Kulshreshtha. But is there a risk of the cricket being overshadowed by all the razzmatazz? “Innovations happen with the interest of the viewer in mind. The agenda always is to improve the fan experience, but we are not going to oversell,” he says.

WHAT NEXT FOR HOTSTAR?

Disney+ Hotstar, the darling of India’s OTT universe so far with nearly 50 million subscribers, faces an existential challenge, according to some analysts. In the subscription video-on-demand (SVOD) segment, it enjoys a share of 22 per cent, which may drop sharply, with people potentially moving to Voot or Jio, says Elara Capital.

According to Taurani, Hotstar will lose at least 30-40 per cent paid subscribers in the next six to eight months as subscriptions expire. “IPL drives 60-65 per cent of Hotstar numbers. If they don’t replenish it with new cricket rights, the drop will be sharper.”

At present, Hotstar owns the streaming rights for all BCCI cricket matches in India and the rest of the world. It also has the Pro Kabaddi League, the Indian Super League soccer tournament, and rights to premium events like Wimbledon and the English Premier League (EPL). Disney Star had renewed its exclusive broadcast and streaming rights for EPL for the next three seasons (2022 to 2025). For Wimbledon too, it holds the TV and digital rights till 2023.

However, BCCI rights for the next five-year cycle come up for renewal next year. There is no doubt that Reliance and Viacom18 will go at it hammer and tongs to populate their sports library across TV and digital. “One thing we know for sure. Reliance enters a market with one goal in mind—disruption and utter dominance,” says an industry source. “If the path is clear to the management, they will throw their heft behind it.”

And that, as we know, can change the pecking order of sports streaming in India. The game is on! **BT**

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